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THE MARKETS ON FRIDAY

			change †
Sensex	78,918.9	▼	1,097.0
Nifty	24,450.4	▼	315.5
Nifty Futures‡	24,545.7	▲	95.3
Dollar	₹91.8		₹91.6‡‡
Euro	₹106.2		₹106.5‡‡
Brent Crude ($/bbl)	90.3*		83.6‡‡
Gold (10gm)**	₹1,58,115.0	▼	₹1,828.0

† Over previous close; ‡ (January) Premium on Nifty Spot; ‡‡ Previous close; * At 9pm IST; ** Market rate exclusive of VAT; Source: IBJA



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Flipkart cuts about 300 jobs after performance reviews



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IN BRIEF

India okayed urgent docking for Iranian ship in Kochi on Mar 1

India has allowed the urgent docking of an Iranian ship in Kochi and provided accommodation to its 183 crew members, government sources said on Friday. The ship, *IRIS Lavan*, developed urgent technical issues and was granted emergency docking approval on March 1, following a request from the Iranian side, they said. *IRIS Lavan* docked at Kochi on March 4, the sources said. Its 183 crew members are currently accommodated at naval facilities in Kochi, they added. India was approached by the Iranian side days before Iranian warship *IRIS Dena* was sunk by a US submarine using a torpedo off the coast of Sri Lanka. PTI

Forex reserves jump to new high of $728.49 bn

India's foreign exchange reserves rose to a record high of $728.49 billion in the week ended February 27, latest data from the RBI showed. The total reserves increased by $4.88 billion during the week on the back of a rise in gold reserves and foreign currency assets. The previous record high of $726 billion was hit in the week ended February 13. Gold reserves increased by $4.14 billion to $131 billion in the reported week. 6

BS SPECIAL ON SATURDAY

The Iran war and its aftermath

It is in everyone's interest that a functioning state machinery with authority remains in place in Iran,
writes SHYAM SARAN 9

NATIONAL INTEREST

Humiliation and humility

Trump has ushered in the age of humiliation. His method is to push around America's friends rudely and publicly. He knows none of them can afford to fight back,
writes SHEKHAR GUPTA 9

TAKE TWO

Cruising on the road less taken

As women open new doors everywhere, the gaps in motorsports — on and off the track — also stand exposed.
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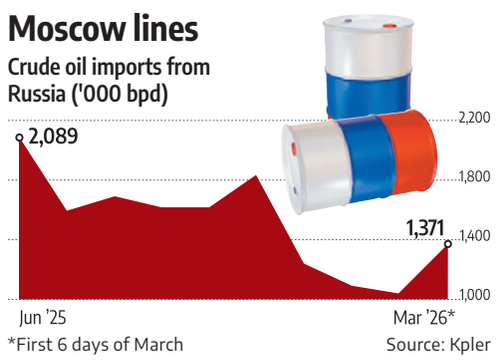


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India bulks up Russia oil; US allows 30-day waiver

Now at a premium, Russian crude imports surge after start of war in West Asia



SHUBHANGI MATHUR & SUDHEER PAL SINGH
New Delhi, 6 March

The United States has issued a temporary 30-day waiver allowing Indian oil refiners to purchase Russian crude currently stranded at sea, as a short-term measure to keep supplies flowing amid disruptions caused by the ongoing Iran war.

The American waiver comes even as India's imports of Russian crude surged to 1.37 million barrels per day (mbpd) in the first six days of March, about 30 per cent higher than the 1.04 mbpd imported from Russia during the whole of February 2026, according to fresh data from trade intelligence firm Kpler.

The waiver expires on April 4, 2026, according to an order issued by the Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) of the US Treasury Department. "To enable oil to keep flowing into the global market, the Treasury Department is issuing a temporary 30-day waiver to allow Indian refiners to purchase Russian oil," US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said in a statement posted on social media platform X on Friday.

Indian refiners have so far lifted only non-sanctioned Russian cargoes, as the US order does not clarify whether the waiver also permits the import of sanctioned oil, according to two people familiar with the development. "The legal teams of oil companies are currently vetting the order to gain a clearer understanding of the matter," a government official said.

In November 2025, the US sanctioned two major Russian oil producers, Rosneft and Lukoil, which accounted for 60 per cent of Moscow's crude supplies to India. Indian refiners have not bought crude from the sanctioned entities since then.

Discounts on Russian oil, which were around $10 a barrel before the crisis in West Asia, have completely eroded and are now being offered at a premium to Indian refiners, the official added. Despite pressure from Western countries, Russia remained India's top crude supplier in February as Indian refiners bought 1.04 mbpd during the month.

The short-term US measure will not provide significant financial benefit to the Russian government because it authorises transactions only for oil already stranded at sea, Bessent said. "India is an essential partner of the United States, and we fully anticipate that New Delhi will ramp up purchases of US oil. This stop-gap measure will alleviate pressure caused by Iran's attempt to take global energy hostage," he added.

Experts say the waiver, along with the ongoing clearing of stranded oil cargoes at sea, could push India's imports of Russian crude to as much as 2 mbpd in the near term, a level last seen in June 2025. "With the waiver now in place, Indian refiners could quickly resume purchases, potentially pushing Russian inflows to around 1.6 to 2 mbpd in the near term. While this provides a short-term logistical buffer, it cannot fully offset India's 2.6 mbpd exposure to West Asian crude, and competition from Chinese buyers for the Russian barrels will limit the upside," said Sumit Ritolia, lead analyst at Kpler. Turn to Page 6

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Govt asks refiners to boost LPG output

Better placed than 1991, but impact may be longer: Govt

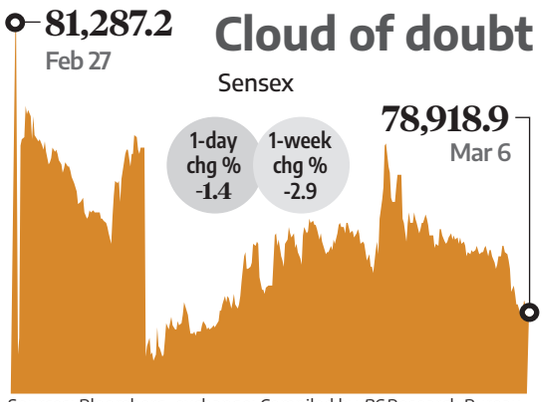
RUCHIKA CHITRAVANSHI
New Delhi, 6 March

There are significant implications for India from the festering conflict in West Asia following United States' and Israel's attack on Iran, the Finance Ministry said on Friday, stressing that the after effects may be longer-lasting in ways not immediately understood.

A prolonged conflict in the region can be detrimental to the economy, placing pressure on inflation, exchange rate, trade and capital flows, the balance of payments, and the current account deficit, the ministry warned in its monthly economic review. Sectors like fertilisers and petrochemicals, dependent on LNG and crude whose prices have risen 9 per cent and 50 per cent, respectively, since the conflict, could be affected too, it noted.

"India enters the next financial year with a solid macroeconomic backdrop, unlike during the previous turbulent episodes in the Gulf region," the review averred, calling the developments since the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei "a pivotal escalation echoing the 1991 Gulf War oil shocks, potentially reshaping global energy geopolitics for decades". Turn to Page 6

Down 3%, Indian stocks log worst week in over one year



Sources: Bloomberg, exchange; Compiled by *BS* Research Bureau

Index	Change % 1-day	1-week
S&P 500*	-1.7	-2.4
Euro Stoxx 50 Pr*	-1.8	-7.5
FTSE 100*	-1.6	-6.1
Nikkei 225	0.6	-5.5
Kospi	0	-10.6
Hang Seng	1.7	-3.3
Nifty 50	-1.3	-2.9
Nifty Midcap 100	-0.7	-2.9
Nifty Smallcap 100	-0.2	-2.5
Nifty PSU Bank	-2	-6.5
Nifty Realty	-2.1	-4.9
Nifty Bank	-2.2	-4.5
India VIX	11.3	45.1
Bullion*		
Gold	1.3	-2.5
Silver	2.0	-10.6

FPIs flee, DIIs keep support
Net investment in Indian equities (₹ cr)

Daily	FPIs	DIIs
Mar 02, 2026	-3,296	8,594
Mar 04, 2026	-8,753	12,068
Mar 05, 2026	-3,753	5,153
Mar 06, 2026	-6,030	6,972
	-21,831	32,787

Source: Exchanges

India mcap	(₹ trn)
Mar 6,'26	449.68
	Chg
1-day	-3.22
1-week	-13.82

	Level	1-day	1-week
₹ vs $ (spot)	91.75	-0.2(%)	-0.8(%)
10-yr bond yield (%)			
India	6.692	5.10 bps	22.98 bps
US	4.167	3.20 bps	3.10 bps

*Until 8:41 pm IST

SAMIE MODAK
Mumbai, 6 March

Domestic equity markets resumed their sharp decline on Friday as petroleum prices renewed their upward climb, with benchmark Brent crude breaching the $90 a barrel mark later in the evening for the first time in almost two years amid the ongoing war in West Asia. The Sensex and the Nifty 50 logged their steepest weekly losses in over a year.

The Sensex fell 1.37 per cent, or 1,100 points, to close at 78,918, while the Nifty 50 declined 1.27 per cent, or 315 points, to settle at 24,450. For the week, both indices dropped nearly 3 per cent — the Nifty 50's worst weekly performance since February 2025 and the Sensex's sharpest fall since December 2024. Both indices ended at their lowest levels since April last year.

During the week, investors' wealth in Indian equity markets declined by nearly ₹14 trillion, including a ₹3.2 trillion loss on Friday. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) offloaded equities worth ₹21,831 crore during the week and around ₹6,000 crore on Friday alone. Domestic institutional investors were net buyers in all four trading sessions this week.

The selloff was triggered by a sharp spike in global crude prices after the US-Israel conflict with Iran intensified as it entered its seventh day, fuelling fears of a much broader disruption to global energy supplies. World shares were mixed on Friday while US markets declined in early trade.

The price for a barrel of Brent crude jumped another 6 per cent to $90.60. During the week, it climbed around 25, the most since March 2022 following Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Turn to Page 6

Brent tops $90/bbl

		($/bbl)
Brent crude*		90.6
Chg (%)	1-day	6.1
	1-week	25.0
WTI crude*		87.8
Chg (%)	1-day	8.4
	1-week	31.0

*Until 20:41 pm IST
Source: Bloomberg

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In a first, K'taka to ban under-16 social media use

Andhra considering similar curbs for those below 13 years of age

AVIK DAS & AASHISH ARYAN
Bengaluru/New Delhi, 6 March

The Karnataka government on Friday proposed banning social media use for children below 16 years of age, becoming the first Indian state to take concrete steps to implement the plan. Andhra Pradesh too announced its intention to introduce curbs on social media use for those under 13.

This comes within three months of Australia banning social media for under 16 for health and safety reasons. Several other countries in Europe are considering similar moves.



"With the objective of preventing adverse effects of increasing mobile usage in children, usage of social media will be banned for children under the age of 16," Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah said on Friday while presenting the state's annual budget.

The government did not immediately explain how it intends to implement the ban or when it will be enforced.

Later in the day, Andhra Pradesh followed suit, with Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu saying his government would look at ways to restrict social media access for children under the age of 13.

Referring to a proposal suggested by IT Minister Nara Lokesh, Naidu said the government would soon launch a programme to prevent children under 13 from accessing social media, likely within the next 90 days.

The government is also discussing possible regulations for the 13–16 age group. A decision will be taken based on wider consensus.

Not just the states, the central government is also considering a similar ban on social media usage by children under a certain age, an official said.

"The contours will have to be decided based on what is the age we want to go ahead with, and if the ban will be complete or allow some form of restricted access. We are discussing all possibilities with the stakeholders," the official said.

Last month, Union Electronics and Information Technology Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, during the AI Impact Summit, said that owing to the ill-effects of social media on children, the idea to ban usage altogether for those below a certain age and below had gained popularity.

According to Vaishnaw, age-based regulation has to be there, and that's something which has now been accepted by many countries. "It was part of our DPDP (Digital Personal Data Protection) Act when we created this age-based differentiation on content which is accessible to young people," Vaishnaw had then told reporters. Turn to Page 6

Small fraud: RBI for relief within 5 days

SUBRATA PANDA
Mumbai, 6 March

Bank customers losing up to ₹50,000 in digital frauds may soon get relief, with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) proposing compensation of up to ₹25,000 as a one-time measure, even if the loss occurred due to the customer's negligence, provided the complaint is lodged within five days of being defrauded.

In draft norms issued on Friday, the regulator said only bona fide victims involving individuals would be compensated by banks within five days of receiving the complaint.

The compensation will be shared between the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and banks, with the central bank bearing the bulk of the payout in the range of 65-76 per cent.

Fraud check
Cases reported and amount lost in various areas of operations

Year	'23-24 ₹ crore	'23-24 Cases	'24-25 ₹ crore	'24-25 Cases	'25-26 (H1) ₹ crore	'25-26 (H1) Cases
Advances	9,160	4,113	31,911	7,934	17,501	4,255
Card/ internet	1,457	29,080	520	13,469	14	195
Deposits	240	2,002	521	1,207	131	222
Total	11,261	36,052	34,771	23,879	21,515	5,092

Source: RBI

During the monetary policy press meet last month, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra had said the customer will be compensated up to ₹25,000 as a one-time measure, "no question asked". Turn to Page 6

Ex-rapper's party heading towards landslide victory in Nepal elections

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
Kathmandu, 6 March

Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah's newly formed Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) was on Friday heading towards a landslide victory in Nepal's first general elections since the violent Gen Z protests toppled the K P Sharma Oli-led government in September 2025.

According to the Election Commission's data available from 144 of the total 165 constituencies, the RSP has won three seats and is ahead in 104 others, local media reported.

The Nepali Congress has won two seats and is leading in 12 others, while the CPN-UML is leading in 10 constituencies. The Nepali Communist Party has won one and is leading in six constituencies.

The outcome is expected to provide a strong government in Nepal, which has had 14 governments in the last 18 years.

The election was being closely watched by India, which hopes for a stable government in the politically fragile Himalayan nation to take forward the developmental partnership between the two sides. "We look forward to working with the new Government of Nepal to further build on the robust multifaceted ties between our two countries and peoples for mutual benefit," Ministry of External Affairs Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in Delhi on Thursday. He said India has "consistently supported peace, progress and stability in Nepal and in keeping with our commitment, provided logistical supplies as per request from Government of Nepal for these elections".

Shah, who was the Mayor of Kathmandu till recently, is leading in Jhapa-5 constituency against four-time prime minister and CPN-UML chair Oli in the latter's stronghold. Shah received 6,551 votes to Oli's 1,428.

Popularly known as 'Balen', the 35-year-old engineer was a popular choice to lead the interim government after Gen Z youths toppled the Oli-led coalition government in September last year, following two-day nationwide violent protests against corruption and a ban on social media.

Balen had declined then to lead the interim government, saying he would rather head the government by contesting the parliamentary election for a full term. In January, he joined the RSP, led by Ravi Lamichhane, and was soon declared the party's PM face.

Among other parties, the Shram Sanskriti Party is leading in six constituencies.

According to an official, Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' won from Rukum Purba district. He secured 10,240 votes against his nearest rival, Lilamani Gautam of CPN (UML), who got 3,462 votes. PTI





Supporters of the Rastriya Swatantra Party, led by rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah, celebrate in Kathmandu, after a landslide victory in Nepal polls PHOTOS: PTI, REUTERS